



◀◀ SUNIL KHLNANI

## LOOKING BACK, FOR LESSONS

The 1950s were the decisive decade, because of what happened and also what did not, because of the wrong turnings and the right moves.

Contemplating the 1950s, most of us slip into torpor. Lodged between the exhilarating, tragic '40s and later decades of manoeuvrings, personality cults, self-mutilations and shimmering aspiration, the '50s seem a black & white newsreel. Press Fast Forward. Even better, Delete.

The settled aura of the 1950s is a trick of retrospective vision. For the 1950s, as lived, were precarious times: years in which solutions to crises—political, economic and international—had to be invented on the fly in testing conditions. To some, this was the era when India took all the wrong turnings: towards socialism, big dams and vast industrial plants, non-alignment, bureaucratic babu-worship. But the truth is, as usual, more complex.

The decade opened with India's future direction in limbo. Gandhi was gone and Patel, with whom Nehru battled for leadership of the Congress party, would be dead by December 1950. Even as Nehru saw off other challengers, he struggled to get a strong grip over his party and government. Inside the Congress, many of his colleagues opposed him, and the regional bosses had real powers. Outside, he faced vigorous criticism from the Hindu right, economic liberals, socialists, Communists, as well as those pressing for recognition of linguistic identities. There was no common political consensus for him to rely on. Nor were there effective instruments—apart from the inherited ics bureaucracy—to engage in what was then called 'nation-building' let alone to aggressively pursue social change.

The crises years of the 1940s had eroded the state's ability to ensure security: the British, preparing for exit, had gradually drawn down state capacities, and the Indian leadership—emerging blinking from jail—was in no position to develop alternatives. In the international domain, India's options were constrained, as pressure built for the country to choose a tent in one or other of the Cold War

camps. Gravest of all was the economic situation: the effects of Partition, which disrupted economic networks and created a large refugee population, were now superimposed upon endemic poverty. Food and basic necessities were in short supply, and capital too was scarce.

Such were the unpropitious circumstances in which India embarked on its great transformation: from a territory where an authoritarian colonial state ruled over a repressive traditional agrarian order into an open democratic society linked into a single economy. As India effects this transition, it turns out the 1950s was the decisive decade. For two reasons: because of what did happen during these years, and equally because of what did not.

The period saw three fundamental accomplishments. Most foundational was the consolidation of the state and its assertion of sovereignty over the social. Law was established as a basic tool for India's self-transformation. Law became the means to express the ambition to abolish caste and remedy historical injustice through 'reservations'. So too, unjust religious practices were changed through reform of Hindu law. Law is usually seen as the principle of stability, rather than of change, in society. India's interpretation was unusual interpretation, and consequential. It gave law and the courts a central role in our politics, not merely in defending rights but in pursuing social goals.

The decade's second defining impulse was the will to create institutions, from the Atomic Energy and Planning Commissions to the Election Commission (a body that has proved crucial to maintaining India as a democracy). The performance of these institutional spawn was, and is, uneven. But overall, the energy invested in creating new institutions gave public life a structural density that has helped to sustain an open society.

Third, the state secured the subcontinent as a zone of relative peace with conditions of economic stability under